

Chapter

The Company You Keep Shapes Your Destiny — How to Sustain Sattva Guna



Introduction: How Does Sattva Last?

Through sadhana and the Guru's grace, **sattva** awakens within the seeker — peace, clarity and an inclination toward truth. But awakening is one thing; staying awake is another. In this discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji raises a direct question and gives an equally direct answer:

"How do you continue the sattva within you? Very simple. It comes from keeping company with people of sattva guna, and with those who will lead you toward truth."

This whole chapter unfolds this one principle: **as the company, so the quality.**

1. Company Shapes Thought, Thought Shapes Conduct

Indian philosophy describes three **gunas**, or qualities of nature — **sattva** (purity, knowledge, peace), **rajas** (desire, restlessness, show) and **tamas** (inertia, attachment, ignorance). Acharya Ji says that which guna grows within us depends largely on the people around us:

"If your company is of rajas, then slowly your guna will come down."

This influence of company works silently and constantly:

"The people around you, your locality — where you live — from that, sanskaras go inside you non-stop."

Sanskaras are the impressions made on the mind, which in time become one's nature. And from here the whole chain runs:

"Your conduct is according to your thoughts. And what your thoughts are like depends on what kind of people you live among."

Company → **sanskaras** → **thoughts** → **conduct**. Change the first link of this chain, and the rest change by themselves. Acharya Ji puts it in one sentence:

"It is the company you keep that decides."

2. When You Rise Above Your Family

When the seeker's level rises through the Guru's grace, a new situation arises — they begin to stand apart among their own relatives:

"If you rise from the family, then you feel that you have risen very high — above all the cousins and everyone."

Here Acharya Ji's advice is clear:

"Then leave this world. That is, you do not need to meet them much."

When You Meet, Meet at Their Level

This is not about breaking ties. Acharya Ji also explains how to behave when you must attend a family gathering:

"If you come to a function, come down to their level. At that time, only as much topic as they like. Don't babble on that 'we are of such a level, I achieved this, I achieved that.'"

Boasting about one's achievements is itself a form of rajas. If something big must be said, let it be to lift others:

"If you want to talk about such things, then talk about bringing these people up too — 'You can also do business.'"

New Company, a New Circuit

Having reached a higher level, the seeker needs new companions:

"You have arrived here, so you will have to give them up a little. If they seem low level, then new-level friends should come into your life here. Then your circuit will change. These blood relations from birth — go to meet them once in a while. Then your sattva will be maintained."

3. How the Fall Happens: Comfort, Attachment and Show

Acharya Ji also lays bare the subtle trap in which a seeker who has risen comes back down:

"What is the problem? By the Guru's grace you rise higher and higher, comfort starts coming, and you get bound in comfort. And there is also the attachment of **tamas**, so you feel the desire to go back to those same low-level relationships."

Then, having gone there, the seeker starts showing off their progress — and that is where the decline begins:

"You come down from here, and then you start showing off to them in **rajas**. They are least interested in how high you have gone. Then you feel bad about them, then they keep speaking ill of you, and then your **sattva guna** slowly goes down."

This sequence is worth noting:

- The Guru's grace brings **comfort**, and the seeker gets bound in it.
- **The attachment of tamas** pulls toward old relationships.
- Once there, the show of **rajas** begins.
- The others have no interest in it; **bitterness** grows on both sides.

- In the end, **sattva** slowly goes down.

4. Three Paths

To come out of this situation, Acharya Ji lays out the options:

"Either bring them up to this level, or bring your friends. If you cannot bring them, then come down and interact for that much time — but it will be waste of time."

And Acharya Ji's clear preference is toward building new company:

"Bring new people of your own to this level. New friends, you will have to bring everything new — a new family. Have you understood or not?"

5. Why Great Souls Leave Home

This is why many great souls in history stepped out of the circle of household life:

"That is why great souls often leave home. You will get only one of the two. If you achieve something very big in the world outside, then this home slowly falls away. Very few people's entire family rises up."

The remedy for sustaining sattva here is the company of the Guru:

"So to maintain sattva guna there is no choice — you have to spend the maximum time with the Guru. At home there will often be people of rajas and tamas, in maya. That is how the nature is made."

6. The Truth of the Ganesh Purana: Even in the Homes of Avatars

As evidence for this, Acharya Ji refers to the **Ganesh Purana**:

"Just read the Ganesh Purana. It is given in the Ganesh Purana — relatives are mostly there only for their own gain. Ganesh himself says this."

This is not an accusation against any one family, but a general **tattva** (principle):

"That is, he said it as a **tattva** — meaning it will be in everyone's family, in ours, in everyone around."

Shri Ram, Shri Krishna and Shivaji Maharaj

Then Acharya Ji gives examples from the lives of avatars and great men:

"Wasn't it like that in Shri Ram's own home? 'Send him to the forest for fourteen years' — was it like that in Shri Ram's own home or not? Was there Kansa and others in Shri Krishna's family or not?"

"Arre, it happens in the homes of avatars and gods! Weren't there such people in Shri Shivaji Maharaj's home too? Someone — Soyarabai — used to say, didn't she: 'Keep this kingdom for my son; give your Sambhaji Raje the south below, and give Rajaram Ji the part above.'"

The conclusion is simple:

"So if this happens even in the homes of great avatars, why would it not happen in your home? There will be people of rajas and tamas."

7. The Decision of Viveka-Buddhi

A seeker with **viveka-buddhi** — the discerning intelligence that tells right from wrong, the eternal from the passing — accepts this reality and chooses their path. Acharya Ji places the essence of the whole discourse here:

"A person with viveka-buddhi understands that mostly there will be people of rajas and tamas around, and in my relations too. So one — I am doing great work, so I will have to rise above them. Or I will have to lift them up and bring them along too. Otherwise I will have to come to their level and talk only about what they like. Otherwise I will have to bring my own new family, everything new."

"Sometimes, if I cannot break the relationship, I should go to them — becoming of their level. That is how you can maintain sattva guna; otherwise you cannot."

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 Sattva is sustained by company** — keep company with people of sattva and with those who lead toward truth.
- 2 Company → sanskaras → thoughts → conduct** — the people around us constantly imprint sanskaras on us. *It is the company you keep that decides.*
- 3 Meet relatives at their level** — do not boast of your achievements; if you must speak, speak of lifting them up.
- 4 Recognize the trap of the fall** — bondage to comfort, the attachment of tamas and the show of rajas together bring sattva down.
- 5 Three paths** — bring them up, or meet them briefly at their level, or build your own new company, a new family.

- 6 **Maximum time with the Guru** — this is the way to sustain sattva guna.
- 7 **This is the law of nature** — according to the Ganesh Purana, relatives are mostly there for their own gain; even in the homes of Shri Ram, Shri Krishna and Shivaji Maharaj there were people of rajas and tamas.